

The Emperor's Dietician and the Well-Traveled Dumpling

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In 1330, a court dietician named Hu Sihui compiled a nutrition manual for Buyantu Khan, the Yuan emperor of Mongol China. The manuscript, *Yinshan Zhengyao*, was not a Chinese cookbook in any narrow sense: Hu Sihui served a court that ruled from Beijing to the steppe, and his recipes reflect it, drawing on Mongolian, Central Asian, and even Middle Eastern dishes alongside Chinese ones (Buell and Anderson 2010). Among them is a dumpling called *manta*, stuffed with knife-chopped fatty mutton, onion, and cumin. It is the earliest written trace of the dish now eaten, under slightly different names, from Xinjiang to Istanbul.

That single point of origin is unusually well documented for a food this old, and the documentation points toward a fairly specific mechanism of spread. The word itself is telling: linguists trace *manti* to the Chinese *mantou*, a steamed bun-shaped bread already known by that name under the Jin dynasty, centuries earlier. Turkic languages appear to have borrowed the term outward from Chinese rather than the reverse, which puts the direction of transmission in China and the timing at the Mongol Empire's height, when Turkic and Mongol populations lived, fought, and traded across the same imperial territory as northern China.

The dish did not stay put. Historian Holly Chase has argued that "Turkic and Mongol horsemen on the move are supposed to have carried frozen or dried *manti*, which could be quickly boiled over a campfire" (Chase 2000), turning a court recipe into road food for an empire built on cavalry. That image explains a geography that would otherwise look like coincidence: the same dumpling, under cognate names, in Uyghur, Uzbek, and Kazakh cooking; as *mantu* in Afghanistan; as *mant'i* in Armenia; as *mandu* in Korea; and as *mantı* in Turkey, where it arrived last, carried by Turkic migration into Anatolia long after Hu Sihui's court had already written it down.

Compare that to a dish like ravioli, whose filled-pasta ancestry in Italy has no comparable paper trail connecting it to any single point of departure; most food historians treat that resemblance to Eurasian dumplings as coincidence, a technique simple enough to be discovered more than once. *Manti* is the opposite case. Its spread is unusual precisely because it can be pinned to an empire, a set of trade and migration routes, and a single Chinese root word, rather than reconstructed from scattered, independent culinary coincidences. A single court manuscript, written for a single

emperor's table, turns out to be the ancestor of a dish now claimed as thoroughly native by half a dozen different national cuisines. A thirteenth-century snack for horsemen crossing the steppe became, by different roads and at different speeds, a dinner-table staple on both ends of Asia and the edge of Europe.

Works Cited

Buell, Paul D., and Eugene N. Anderson, trans. 2010. *A Soup for the Qan: Chinese Dietary Medicine of the Mongol Era as Seen in Hu Sihui's Yinshan Zhengyao*. 2nd rev. ed. Leiden: Brill.

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